



▲ Semi-divine ruler

The king on this jade plaque is in full royal regalia to indicate his magical status. His shield shows the jaguar god of the underworld. Below him is a dwarf, considered by the Maya to be a living embodiment of maize.

THE COSMIC CYCLE

Mayan magic

The Maya—the indigenous people of Mexico and Central America—had a rich spiritual world. Almost every object, and even days of the week, were considered divine. Rituals and magic were the channels for communicating with the gods.

Living with the spirits

Mayan culture was at its height during the Classic Period, from c. 250 to 900 CE, when the Maya built vast pyramids, temples, and plazas in dozens of city-states. Their religious life was ordered, yet

all-encompassing. Major deities included Chaac, the rain god, and the Maize God, whose specific name is now disputed, but his cycle of death (through harvesting) and rebirth (through seed) was seen to symbolize the Mayan human condition. Gods were honored with temples and inscriptions, and days of the week, cardinal directions, and even rocks were all believed to have spirits, too.

To mediate with this diverse world, the Maya turned to *ah kin* (shamans and priests), who had the power to enter the spirit world through the use of

